A Comparative Study of Users' Information-Seeking Practices Across Search Engines and Generative AI Chatbots

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RESEARCH QUESTIONS RQ1 how do users choose between the two? RQ2 how do sessions and task contexts differ? RQ3 do stated preferences match actual use?

Browse & Verify

241 search sessions · the user keeps control of the sources

what do people actually use search engines for

4 results · drawn from the 241 search sessions coded in the study

Lookup is the core job: 46.1% of search sessions
dl.acm.org › 10.1145/3805712.3809525 › §4.2.3 Tasks
Nearly 3× the chatbot rate (17.8%). Exploratory 31.0%, guidance 22.8%, generative 0%. Search is for finding things, not for making them.

Chosen for relevance, accuracy and traceable sources
dl.acm.org › 10.1145/3805712.3809525 › §4.1.1 Preference categories
Relevance / accuracy 15.8% · functionality 13.3% · familiarity and habit 13.3% · reaching a known site 10.8% · source variety 9.5%.

Topics skew transactional and navigational
dl.acm.org › 10.1145/3805712.3809525 › §4.2.1 Topics
Shopping (r = +3.2), bureaucracy (+2.7) and finance (+2.7) are over-represented: ‘Samsung S25 Ultra case’, ‘DMV near me’, ‘city utilities payment’.

Three in ten sessions end with no further action
dl.acm.org › 10.1145/3805712.3809525 › §4.2.4 Outcomes
The need is met on the page: 29.5% no action, 43.6% acted on it, 2.5% searched again. Habit alone explains 13.3% of tool choice.

Delegate & Consume

247 chatbot sessions · the user hands the work over

what do people actually use ai chatbots for?

Short version: guidance, 34.3% of chatbot sessions against 22.8% on search, plus the things search cannot do at all: writing text, code and images (19.8% versus 0%). People pick me for a synthesised answer (22.3%), speed and capability (19.4% each) and personalisation (17.0%). Out of habit? Almost never (0.8%).

what do they bring you instead of a search engine?

The personal and the consequential: self and social skills (15.8%, the strongest skew in the study), as in ‘how long should I hold out for a response after a date?’, and health (10.9%). 66% of those guidance conversations end in a real-world action.

THE GAP

Users call chatbots the efficient option, then ask them the highest-stakes questions, and act on the answer.

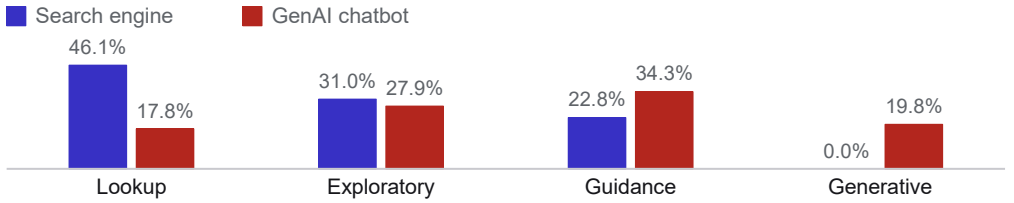
METHOD

84 US adults, recruited on Prolific, surveyed February 2025. Each opened their own history and reflected on their last three search sessions and last three chatbot sessions: the goal, what triggered it, what they did, what they did next, and why that tool.



500 reported → 488 coded; two coders, Cohen's κ 0.83–0.96.

EVIDENCE · TASK TYPE PER SESSION ($\chi^2 = 84.6$, $p < .001$)



LIMITS · AND OUR QUESTION TO YOU

84 digitally literate Prolific users, not the general population. Sessions are self-reported and taken one at a time, so strategies that span tools stay invisible. Captured February 2025, before AI Mode.

Does the gap close once chatbots cite their sources, or do people simply stop clicking?

Summarises Lichtenegger, Urman & Hannák (2026), SIGIR '26, 1094–1105, CC BY 4.0. The results page and the chat are our illustrations of the paper's findings, not screenshots; queries in quotation marks are participant examples given in the paper.